



Phone Fundamentals

Ace Dispatch · Dispatcher Training Course

Module 4 of 18 · Foundations · about a 12-minute read

Two dispatchers call the same broker about the same load, ten minutes apart. The first one says: "Uh, hi, yeah... I'm calling about that, um, the Dallas load? Is that, like, still available?" There's a pause. The broker sighs, quotes a number on the low side, and privately decides this person doesn't really know what they're doing.

The second one says: "Hi, this is [your name] with Summit Carriers — I'm calling on your Atlanta-to-Dallas load, the dry van. Is it still open?" Crisp. Calm. Sure of herself. The broker perks up, gives her the real rate, and a few loads later starts calling her first when something good comes up.

Same load. Same truck behind both of them. The only difference was thirty seconds on the phone — and in this job, your voice is your reputation before you've proven anything else.

WHAT YOU'LL BE ABLE TO DO

Carry yourself on the phone like a professional dispatcher: sound confident and clear, listen so you don't miss things, follow the basic etiquette brokers expect, and stay organized while you talk. You won't learn the booking call itself yet — that's coming soon — but every single call you ever make is built on what's in the next few minutes.

1 The Phone *Is* the Job

Start with a plain truth: dispatching happens on the phone. Email has its place — documents and confirmations — but loads get booked, rates get negotiated, and problems get solved by talking, live, voice to voice. Deals move fast, and the phone is where they move.

Here's what that means for you. When a broker picks up and hears your voice, **you are the company**. They can't see your office or your trucks — your voice is the entire impression Summit Carriers makes in that moment, and brokers form it in the first few seconds. Sound prepared and confident, and they treat you like a pro who can cover their freight. Sound lost and unsure, and they'll either pass on you or quietly decide they can push you around on the rate. None of that is about how much you *know* yet — it's about how you carry yourself, and carrying yourself well is completely learnable.

2 How You Sound

A few simple things move the needle more than anything fancy.

First, slow down. The number-one tell of a nervous beginner is racing. Slow your pace just a little and you instantly sound more confident — and you're easier to understand when you're rattling off a lane and a rate.

Second, kill the filler. "Um," "uh," "like," "I think maybe," "sort of." Every one chips away at your credibility. Hear the difference between *"Um, I think we could maybe do that?"* and *"Yes, we can cover that."* Same message, completely different person on the other end. And when you genuinely don't know something, don't mumble a guess — say *"Let me confirm that and call you right back."* That sounds *more* professional, not less.

Third, bring a little energy — and smile. It sounds corny, but it's real: smiling changes the sound of your voice, and sitting up straight changes it too. Flat and mumbling reads as bored or green; warm and clear reads as someone who's good at their job. And keep it clean on your end — a quiet room, a solid connection, no chewing or TV in the background.

3 Etiquette Brokers Expect

None of it is complicated — it just has to be consistent.

Be ready before you dial. Have the load details, your truck's information, and your notes in front of you so you're not scrambling while someone waits on the line.

Identify yourself right away — your name and your company: *"This is [your name] with Summit Carriers."* It tells the broker instantly who they're dealing with and sets a professional tone from word one.

Respect their time. Brokers are busy and juggling a stack of calls. Be friendly, but get to the point.

Be responsive — and this one's bigger than it sounds. Return calls and messages quickly. In freight, the dispatcher who calls back in five minutes gets the load that the one who calls back tomorrow doesn't. Responsiveness is reputation; it's a huge part of why a broker works with you again.

THE SIMPLE RULE FOR PHONE VS. EMAIL

Talk to make the deal, email to document it. Use the phone for anything live or time-sensitive — booking a load, working a rate, handling a problem. Use email for anything that needs to be *in writing* — sending your paperwork, getting the rate confirmation, putting an agreement on record.

4 Listening & Confirming

Here's the part beginners underrate: half of being good on the phone is *listening*.

Let the other person finish. Don't talk over them, don't jump in. You'll catch details you'd otherwise miss, and people trust someone who actually listens instead of just waiting to talk.

Then do the single habit that prevents more mistakes than anything else: **confirm the key details back.** When a broker gives you a load, repeat the important parts out loud before you hang up — *"Okay, so that's Atlanta to Dallas, picking up Tuesday morning, thirty-eight thousand pounds of furniture, three thousand on the rate. Do I have that right?"* Ten seconds, and it catches a wrong pickup date or a misheard rate *before* it turns into a stranded driver. Brokers respect it, too — it signals you're careful.

And **listen for what's underneath the words**. Is the broker in a hurry to cover this load? Are they vague when you ask for details? You won't act on all of it yet — but training your ear now pays off in every negotiation and problem call down the road.

5 Stay Organized: Notes & Voicemail

Last piece: stay organized *while* you talk, because you'll run dozens of calls in a day and they blur together fast. Memory is not a plan.

Take notes on every call: who you spoke with, the load and its details, what you agreed to, and anything you promised to follow up on or any time you said you'd call back. Those notes protect you when there's a question later about what was said — and they keep you from dropping commitments, which is exactly how a dispatcher loses a broker's trust.

VOICEMAIL, DONE RIGHT
Keep it short and complete, said slowly: *"Hi, this is [your name] with Summit Carriers, calling about your Atlanta-to-Dallas load. Please call me back at [number]."* Who you are, your company, the load, your callback number. And make sure your *own* greeting is clean and professional — brokers will hear it.

Phone Presence — at a glance

The whole lesson on one page. Keep it by the phone before a call.

Sounds green	Sounds like a pro
Races through it, nervous	Slows down — steady, easy to follow
"Um, uh, like, I think maybe..."	No filler — "Yes, we can cover that."
Never says who's calling	Names self + company first thing
Mumbles a guess when unsure	"Let me confirm that and call you right back."
Flat, bored, distracted	Warm energy, sitting up, a smile in the voice
TV or noise in the background	Quiet room, clear connection
Hangs up without checking	Repeats the key details back to confirm
Forgets what was said	Takes notes on every call

Walkthrough — Hear the Difference

The same moment, two ways. We're listening to how she carries herself — not how to book (that's its own lesson).

The weak version

Broker: "Smith Logistics, this is Greg."

Dispatcher: "Yeah hi, um, I saw a load, I think it was going to Dallas? Is that, like, still around?"

Broker: "...Which load? I've got a few. Who's this?"

Dispatcher: "Oh, sorry — uh, we're a carrier, we've got a truck I think near there maybe?"

→ *Greg can't tell who he's talking to, which load they mean, or whether they're for real. He's already half-decided to lowball or move on.*

The strong version

Broker: "Smith Logistics, this is Greg."

Dispatcher: "Hi Greg, this is [your name] with Summit Carriers. I'm calling on your Atlanta-to-Dallas furniture load, the dry van — is it still open?"

Broker: "It is. Picks up tomorrow, delivers Thursday."

Dispatcher: "Got it — Atlanta to Dallas, pickup tomorrow, deliver Thursday. [writing it down] What's the weight and the rate you're working with?"

→ *Greg knows exactly who this is, which load, and that they're organized. He gives a straight answer and takes them seriously.*

She identified herself and her company, named the exact load, didn't reach for a single "um," let Greg answer, confirmed the details back, and took a note — all in a few seconds. She hasn't negotiated or booked anything yet; that's still ahead. She just sounded like a professional. That alone changes how the whole call goes.

Check yourself

Try these from memory first, then check your answers below.

1. Name three things that make you sound more credible on the phone.
2. A broker quickly rattles off a load's lane, dates, weight, and rate. What should you do before you hang up, and why?
3. Why does identifying yourself and your company in the first sentence matter so much?
4. When should you use the phone, and when should you use email?
5. What should every call note capture?

ANSWERS

1. Any three of: slow your pace; cut filler words; bring energy / smile; speak clearly from a quiet space; identify yourself and your company up front.
2. Repeat the key details back to confirm ("So that's Atlanta to Dallas, Tuesday pickup, 38,000 lbs, \$3,000 — right?"). It catches mishearings before they cause real problems, and signals you're careful.
3. On the phone you *are* the company to the broker; a clear, immediate identification sets a professional tone and tells them exactly who they're dealing with.
4. Phone for anything live or time-sensitive (booking, working a rate, solving a problem); email for anything that needs to be in writing (paperwork, the rate confirmation, an agreement on record). Talk to make the deal, email to document it.
5. Who you spoke with, the load and its details, what was agreed, and anything you committed to follow up on or a callback time.

WHAT'S NEXT → MODULE 5: READING A LOAD BOARD POSTING

That's Foundations complete — the language, the players and the money, equipment, and now how to carry yourself on the phone. The groundwork is done; it's time to actually start working a truck. The very first thing a dispatcher does every day is hunt for freight — so next, we pull up a real posting and read it field by field, so you can find the loads worth chasing.

YOUR COMPANY'S PLAYBOOK

This lesson covers phone professionalism for any dispatcher. Your own operation adds its specifics — its standard greeting, its expected call-back time, where call notes live (the CRM/dispatch system and what to log), and any phone tools or norms (shared inbox, after-hours coverage, when to escalate to a manager). *Your trainer or supervisor will fill these in.*